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TECHNICAL QUALIFICATION NARRATIVES

Challenge • Context • Action • Result (CCAR) | Prepared for agency interviews

How to use: OPM's 2025 SES guidance prohibits TQ narratives in the application; TQs must be shown in the two-page resume and are probed in the agency interview. Replace these TQ titles with the exact wording in the vacancy announcement, then use the narratives to prepare and reduce each one to key points.

TQ 1 EXPERT KNOWLEDGE OF FEDERAL BUDGET FORMULATION, EXECUTION, AND APPROPRIATIONS LAW

Key elements: *Apportionment and allotment • Funds control • Continuing resolutions • Spend planning*

Managing funds control for $24B and cutting year-end lapsed funds 63% at USDA (2017–2021)

CHALLENGE

As Director of Budget Execution and Funds Control at USDA, I was responsible for apportionment, allotment, and funds control for $24B in discretionary and mandatory accounts. My challenge was to get money to programs on time and stop funds from lapsing unused at year-end.

CONTEXT

Each year, millions of dollars expired unspent because program offices received allotments late and had no clear view of their spending. Repeated continuing resolutions made planning harder, and several accounts with different periods of availability and legal limits required careful control to stay within appropriations law.

ACTION

- **Fixed the front end:** I rebuilt the apportionment process with OMB, setting a fixed calendar so allotments reached program offices weeks earlier, including standing plans for operating under continuing resolutions.
- **Made spending visible:** I launched a spend-plan dashboard that compared every program's planned and actual obligations each month, flagging funds at risk of lapsing in time to redirect them lawfully.
- **Held mid-year reviews:** I led mid-year and fourth-quarter reviews with program leaders to move unneeded funds to priorities, within each account's purpose and transfer authority.
- **Led the team:** I directed a 35-person staff and trained program budget officers on funds control and periods of availability.

RESULT

- Cut year-end lapsed funds 63%.
- Delivered allotments to program offices on schedule, including through continuing resolutions.
- Kept $24B in accounts free of Anti-Deficiency Act violations.

TQ 2 DEMONSTRATED LEADERSHIP OF FINANCIAL REPORTING, INTERNAL CONTROLS, AND AUDIT REMEDIATION

Key elements: *OMB Circular A-123 • Payment integrity • Risk assessment • Corrective action*

Cutting improper payments from 6.1% to 2.4% through internal control reform (FY2021–FY2024)

CHALLENGE

When I became Deputy CFO, the Department's improper payment rate was 6.1%, putting it out of compliance with the Payment Integrity Information Act. I chair the Senior Assessment Team that oversees internal control under OMB Circular A-123, and my challenge was to bring payments under control.

CONTEXT

Improper payments came mostly from missing documentation and payments made before eligibility was confirmed. Internal control testing was done as a yearly paperwork exercise rather than a tool for finding and fixing risk, and recoveries of overpayments were slow.

ACTION

- **Assessed the risk:** I directed a risk assessment of every high-dollar payment program and found which controls failed most often and why.
- **Strengthened controls:** I required pre-payment eligibility checks against Treasury's Do Not Pay system and set documentation standards that every program had to meet before paying.
- **Made A-123 work:** I turned the Senior Assessment Team into a quarterly working session where program owners reported test results and corrective actions, with dates I tracked to closure.
- **Recovered funds:** I set up a dedicated recovery team to pursue overpayments promptly.

RESULT

- Reduced the improper payment rate from 6.1% to 2.4%.
- Recovered $38M for taxpayers.
- Returned the Department to Payment Integrity Information Act compliance, supporting its first unmodified audit opinion in six years.